

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mrs soumya hegde

Address: 32 non suchcourtavenue Ewell Ewell, Surrey KT17 2RU

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment:1. Impact on Residential Character, Traffic and Safety

Belmont is a well-established, quiet residential neighbourhood. I lived in the area for over eight years and, although I now reside nearby in Ewell, I continue to visit frequently due to close community ties.

The introduction of a large community hall or place of worship would significantly alter the peaceful nature of the area and undermine its residential character. Dorset Road already experiences heavy traffic during peak hours, and this development would inevitably increase congestion, parking pressure, and road safety risks.

Of particular concern is the close proximity of a primary school. Increased vehicle and pedestrian traffic associated with the proposed use would create additional safety hazards for children walking to and from school.

There are also nearby sports and recreational facilities that already contribute to traffic levels. Further intensification of use would make local roads increasingly difficult to navigate and unsuitable for a quiet suburban environment.

For these reasons, I strongly object to this proposal and respectfully request that the Council prioritise the preservation of residential amenity and public safety.

2. Community Cohesion and Integration Considerations (Casey Review 2016)

The Casey Review (2016) highlighted the risks of residential and cultural segregation, often described as the development of "parallel lives." It warned that large, concentrated single-faith facilities can contribute to social clustering, which may lead to:

- Reduced day-to-day interaction between different communities
- Weakened social integration and shared civic identity

- The formation of segregated enclaves

Experiences in nearby areas such as Morden, as well as across several London boroughs including Tooting, Tower Hamlets, Newham, Barking and Dagenham, Waltham Forest, Brent, Ealing and Hounslow, demonstrate how significant demographic clustering has followed the establishment of large-scale, single-use religious centres.

Similar trends are evident nationally in towns and cities such as Watford, Birmingham, Bradford and Leeds.

In a borough already facing pressures on infrastructure and social cohesion, the Council should prioritise developments that bring diverse communities together through shared, neutral spaces rather than facilities that risk reinforcing separation.

I respectfully request that the Council undertake a formal assessment of the long-term community impacts observed in comparable areas before approving additional single-faith developments.

3. Conflict with Sutton Local Plan (2018) - Policies 21 and 23

The proposed development appears to conflict with the Council's own planning framework:

Policy 21 - Social Infrastructure

This policy requires social infrastructure to be sustainable, inclusive and balanced across communities. Approving additional specialised facilities for groups that are already well-served risks creating disproportionate provision and undermines equitable access to community resources.

Policy 23 - Environmental Protection and Impact

Developments must be appropriate to their location and character. Given the existing concentration of faith-specific facilities within the surrounding area, further intensification of single-use religious provision would contribute to a monocultural land use pattern that is inconsistent with Sutton's diverse suburban character.

4. Disproportionate Provision in Relation to Local Demographics

According to the 2021 Office for National Statistics Census for the London Borough of Sutton, the religious composition is approximately:

- Christian - 45.8% (95,983 residents) - multiple churches
- No religion - 32.3% (67,779 residents) - limited neutral community spaces
- Muslim - 7.0% (14,722 residents) - multiple mosques
- Hindu - 7.0% (14,663 residents) - no dedicated worship facilities
- Other faiths combined - approximately 1%

Despite Muslim and Hindu populations being of equal size, only one group benefits from multiple dedicated facilities. Granting further specialised provision without addressing this imbalance represents inequitable resource distribution.

I respectfully request that the Council conduct a borough-wide audit of existing places of worship and shared community facilities against demographic need before determining this application.

5. Evidence of Existing Provision

Planning decisions must be guided by objective assessments of need. Current provision already

includes several operational Islamic centres within Sutton and nearby areas, including:

- Sutton Central Masjid - Carshalton Road
- Sutton Islamic Centre - Oakhill Road
- Muslim Cultural & Welfare Association of Sutton - Wentworth Hall, Carshalton
- Masjid Abu Bakar Al-Siddiq - Rosehill
- Baitul Futuh Mosque and Morden Islamic Community Centre (major regional facilities)

In contrast, other faith groups and over one-third of residents who identify with no religion lack access to neutral, shared community infrastructure.

Approving further specialised provision without addressing this imbalance is inconsistent with the National Planning Policy Framework's requirement to plan positively for inclusive shared spaces for all sections of the community.